THE NOBULOUS SET · GAME ONE

Designed by Jonathan Weeks

Build-a-Tyrant (BAT)

Four scientists, one boss, and every failure makes it stronger.

Four Lab Rats work their benches in Nobulous' laboratory, resolving Experiments and bolting salvaged Upgrades onto themselves. Every Experiment they fail donates material to the thing growing in the tank. Five Splices and it wakes up. Then they have to kill it.

COMPONENTS

- 4 double-sided Lab Rat cards
- 20 Experiment cards
- 16 regular Upgrade cards (4 each of Power, Mobility, Defense, Senses)
- 8 Specimen cards
- 7 Tyrant Attack cards
- 1 Buff HP track card (15 spaces) — *optional, see Fine-tuning*
- **From 20 Strong:** the 17 unit dice — 4 Purple, 4 Blue, 4 Green, 4 Yellow, 1 Red
- **From 20 Strong:** the **Strategy die**, which marks the active Lab Rat all game; the **Health die**; the **Health dial**, which tracks the Tyrant in the battle; and the Chip. The Recovery die is not used.

SETUP

1. Choose one side for each of the four Lab Rat cards. That side is fixed for the game. Place all four Rats in a row/column — every Rat is in play at once.
2. Give each Rat one Purple, one Blue, one Green and one Yellow die. These are that Rat's **personal dice** and stay at their own workbench.
3. Place the Red die on a randomly selected Lab Rat. Red is communal and belongs to no Rat.
4. Choose a difficulty. It sets the **Specimens** added to the Upgrade deck and the Tyrant's **Health**.

DIFFICULTY	SPECIMENS	TYRANT HEALTH
Easy	5	9
Standard	6	10
Hard	7	12
Nobulous	8	14

   Shuffle that many random Specimens in with the 16 regular Upgrades. Return the rest to the box.
5. Shuffle the 20 Experiments into a face-down deck.
6. Leave room for the **Tyrant Splices** and the **Tyrant Attack deck**.

OBJECT OF THE GAME

The game is split into two parts: the **Splice Phase** and the **Tyrant Battle**. Five Splices awaken the Tyrant. You cannot avoid this — the game is about *which* five cards it gets and *what shape your Rats are in* when it stands up. Defeat the Tyrant to win.

THE SPLICE PHASE (A TURN)

1. Reveal the next Experiment card.
2. Reveal 2 cards from the Upgrade deck. If either is a Specimen, increase this Experiment's Target by **+1** (once only, even if both are Specimens).
3. Choose which Rat is active and put the **Strategy die** on it *after* seeing the Experiment and the two Upgrades. The same Rat may be chosen on consecutive turns.
4. Place the set-aside Red die on a **non-active** Rat.
5. Resolve any ability that triggers after selection but before dice are committed.
6. Commit dice, roll, and resolve (below).
7. Exhaust the committed personal dice, resolve Red and any borrowed die, then recover dice equal to that Rat's REC.

Committing and rolling

The active Rat may commit any number of its own available dice, plus Red if it holds it, plus at most one borrowed die. Hits and Crits count toward the Experiment Target.

> **SUCCESS**
>
> Roll successes greater than or equal to the Target value and satisfy any printed restriction. The active Rat takes **one** of the two revealed Upgrades (max 3 per Rat). Discard the other upgrade.

> **FAILURE**
>
> Splice the stronger revealed Upgrade into the Tyrant — add it face-up to the **Tyrant Splices** stack near the Tyrant Attack deck. Discard the other upgrade. If the two are equal in Value, choose either card.

Zero-dice turns

A Rat may be selected and commit nothing. The Experiment fails automatically and the stronger Upgrade is Spliced. Recovery still happens. This is a legal choice, not a rest action — it gives no bonus.

UPGRADES

Every Upgrade card includes three elements: a **category** (Power, Mobility, Defense or Senses), a **Value**, and a printed **tap effect**.

- During the **Splice Phase**, the Value indicates which of two revealed cards is the *stronger* one — the one that gets Spliced when you fail. Holding Upgrades also limits which dice you may borrow from other rats.
- During the **Tyrant Battle** a Value is a **threshold**: damage to a Tyrant Splice must meet or exceed this threshold in a single attack in order to be removed. A Rat's Upgrade blocks one attack and is spent (see *Armor*). Tapping a card (Rats only) uses its printed effect.
- A Rat may hold at most **3** Upgrades. Specimens count against that limit.

The Tyrant holds Spliced Upgrades differently. It never taps, and a Splice's printed effect is **never used** — on the Tyrant a card is only its Value. What it costs you is the die it takes with it when it breaks (see *Breaking a Splice*).

BORROWING

The active Rat may borrow **one** available non-Red die from another Rat, before either Strategy roll. The more Upgrades the borrower already holds, the worse the die it is allowed to take:

UPGRADES HELD	MAY BORROW	BANISH RISK
0	Purple, Blue, Green or Yellow	17%
1	Blue, Green or Yellow	33%
2	Green or Yellow	50%
3	Yellow only	67%

After the Experiment resolves, roll the borrowed die by itself. On a miss it is **banished** — removed from the game permanently. On a hit or Crit it returns to its owner exhausted.

THE RED DIE

- Red is communal, is never banished, and belongs to no workbench.
- If the active Rat holds Red, it may commit it normally.
- After Red is used it is **set aside** rather than exhausted.
- At the start of the next turn, after the active Rat has been chosen, place the set-aside Red on any **non-active** Rat. If Red was not used it is not set aside, and this step is skipped.

During the Tyrant Battle the Red die works differently. It is not included in the shared pool, nor is it passed around. **The attacking Rat may commit it, but only if they do not tap an Upgrade as part of the attack.** The Red die is set aside afterwards instead of being exhausted.

AWAKENING THE TYRANT

The Tyrant awakens the moment it reaches **5 Splices**. Build the **Tyrant track**; from left to right, place the five Tyrant Splices **in a random order**, and then the **Health dial**, set to your difficulty's Tyrant Health. Once complete, begin the battle.

Splicing Machine Malfunction. If the Experiment deck runs out first, randomly select enough unused Upgrade cards to bring the Tyrant to exactly 5 Splices, apply them, and begin the battle. Running out of *Upgrade* cards is not a malfunction — reshuffle the Upgrade discard instead.

THE TYRANT BATTLE

Setting up the fight

1. Shuffle the 7 **Tyrant Attack** cards face-down, then **flip the top card** face-up to start the Attack discard. It does not attack; it only supplies the first **commit color** (see *Committing by color*).
2. The **Tyrant track** runs the five shuffled Splices, then Health. That is the order damage has to chew through. Nothing marks a Splice: **a Splice is never part-damaged**, so it is either whole or gone.
3. Its bulk is the five Splices — the dial is only what is left once the last wall comes down, and the fight is won by breaking them. Take **2 Purple, 2 Blue, 1 Green and 1 Yellow** out of the Rats' personal dice — there are only 17 in the game, so the Tyrant's six come from the Rats' own supply. Keep them in a bag. Those six never exhaust; the Tyrant draws from them fresh every round.
   If a color is short — borrowing banished too many of it — take dice of that color back out of the banished pile to make up the number. They are not returned to the Rats; they go straight into the bag. If there is no die of that color anywhere, the Tyrant simply goes without and draws from a smaller bag. It was assembled out of your equipment either way.
4. Sweep every personal die still in the game — from all four Rats, available *and* exhausted — into one **shared battle pool**, all available. Banished dice stay gone. **Red is not part of the pool**; it is available to the attacking Rat every round, on the terms described under *The Red die*.
5. Each Rat keeps its own Health and its own Upgrades. **Lab Rat abilities do not apply in the battle** — they are laboratory technique, and help only with Experiments.

A battle round

1. **Untap.** Every Upgrade tapped last round untaps now.
2. **Choose the attacking Rat** from those still standing and move the **Strategy die** to it. It uses its own Upgrades; its printed ability is silent here.
3. **Commit as many dice as you like** from the shared battle pool, **honoring the commit color**, and roll them — no limit, but you only get **REC + 2** back. Every hit is 1 damage and every Crit is 2, and **STR 2** gives a second Strategy roll here too.
4. **Either tap one Upgrade or commit Red — not both.** Tapping applies that Upgrade's printed effect, and the card cannot absorb damage until it untaps. Committing Red adds it to the roll on top of your committed dice, for free. A Rat may do neither.
5. **Apply the damage** left to right. **A Splice does not chip:** your blow must **meet its printed Value in this one attack** or it bounces off and the whole attack is wasted. Meet it and the Splice is destroyed outright, and the remainder carries on — it may break the next Splice too, and whatever survives all five comes off Health, which does chip. **Each Splice you break banishes one die of its own color** from the shared pool, or any die if none of that color is left; its printed effect is never used. The Tyrant was built from your equipment and takes some with it.
   The dice you have just committed **are** still pool dice and can be banished: they are not exhausted until the Recover step, which comes after this one. Only when the pool is empty does a banishment reach into the exhausted dice instead.
6. **Recover.** Return dice equal to the attacking Rat's **REC + 2** from the ones you just committed to the shared pool. **The rest are exhausted and do not come back.**
7. If the Tyrant is at 0 Health, the Rats win. Otherwise the Tyrant attacks.
8. **Count the round.** If the Tyrant has survived **8 rounds** it breaks containment and the Rats lose. You have eight attacks to break five walls.

> **COMMITTING BY COLOR**
>
> Every Tyrant Attack card has a colored dot in the top-right corner of its title band (3 Green, 3 Yellow and 1 Blue). **That dot is the commit color.** The one that counts is on the **top card of the Attack discard**. When a Rat attacks it must commit **at least one die of that color**. If no die of that color is available in the shared pool, it must instead commit **two dice of one other color**. **Red never counts** towards the commit color.

The Tyrant's attack

1. Reveal the top **Tyrant Attack** card and apply it. Discard it face-up afterwards; reshuffle the discard if the deck runs out. Its color dot is now the **commit color** for the next Rat attack.
2. The Tyrant draws a number of dice equal to the **highest Value among the Splices it still holds** — 2 if it holds none, never more than its 6 — **at random, without looking**, and rolls them, then return them to the bag.
3. Unless the card says otherwise the attack lands on the **attacking Rat**. Choose one of its *untapped* Upgrades to take the blow: it stops the attack dead, and **it is spent** — discard it, whatever the blow was worth. At most one Upgrade is lost and nothing carries over. Only a Rat with **no** untapped Upgrade takes the damage to its Health (see *Armor*).
4. A Rat reduced to 0 Health is **knocked out**: set it aside and discard its Upgrades. It cannot be chosen as the attacker again.

Reduce the Tyrant to 0 Health to win. The Tyrant wins if **every Rat is knocked out**, or if it **survives 8 rounds**; either way you replay BAT.

Armor

> **TWO KINDS OF ARMOR**
>
> **Neither kind chips** — no card here is ever left part-damaged. A Splice must be met in one blow or it takes nothing; a Rat's Upgrade stops an attack dead whatever it was worth. The difference is the price: a Splice stands until a big enough hit lands, a Rat's Upgrade is **spent the moment it blocks**. The Tyrant's armor is a wall; the Rats' is a budget.

Fine-tuning

Any Health value works, and a single point is a noticeable swing. The **Buff HP card** is optional — hold part of the Health on it and spend that first.

CARRYING BAT FORWARD

Only relevant if you are playing the Nobulous Research Journal (NRJ) campaign, which is Tier III only. Skip otherwise.

BAT contributes its **6 Research Notes**, and nothing leaves the Upgrade deck. A Note you claimed is **retained**, up to 2; one still lying face-up unclaimed is a **candidate**. It does not matter whether you went on to spend it. A retained Note answers **Physical** Exhibits in the finale, reducing a Target by **2**. Claiming one costs the next Upgrade a completed Experiment earns, so the Rats fight thinner for it: BAT is harder so the Imposter is better armed.